

Jeffrey Epstein

Jeffrey Epstein messaged with former CIA director Bill Burns, files show

Spokesperson says Burns 'deeply regrets ever meeting' with Epstein and cut ties after learning of his conviction



📷 William Burns on 24 February 2021 on Capitol Hill in Washington DC. Photograph: Getty Images

Aram Roston *in Washington*

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A new tranche of documents related to convicted sex offender [Jeffrey Epstein](#) revealed several communications with William J Burns, a career diplomat who would go on to become the central intelligence director under Joe Biden.

The documents describe the planning for meetings between Burns and Epstein, two of which occurred, and show Epstein texting with Burns and recommending that other people in his orbit meet with him. The meetings and correspondence occurred after Epstein had [pleaded guilty](#) to

prostitution-related charges in Florida in 2008, including solicitation of prostitution with a minor under the age of 18.

A spokesperson for Burns told the Guardian that the two men had “no relationship”, and that Burns “did not know anything about him, other than that he was introduced as an expert in the financial services sector”. The spokesperson said Burns “deeply regrets ever meeting with him”. Burns has never been accused of any wrongdoing related to Epstein’s crimes.

Burns has decades of diplomatic experience under both Republican and Democratic administrations. During his confirmation hearing to become [CIA](#) director in 2021, even Trump-partisan senator Lindsey Graham called him an “outstanding choice”.

The first mention of Burns in the Epstein files is dated April 2013, when Epstein [emailed](#) an associate, Terje Rød-Larsen, a former Norwegian diplomat, about a meeting: “lets set a meeimg [sic] with Bill burns in wash or ny.” There is no context in the email, or even a subject heading. Rød-Larsen resigned as head of the International Peace Institute in 2020, after revelations that he secured donations from foundations related to Epstein, as well as a personal loan from the financier. He could not be reached for comment.

At the time, Burns was deputy secretary of state, and a key negotiator with Iran under then-secretary of state John Kerry.

In July 2013, [Epstein sent a similar note](#) to Rød-Larsen, apparently following up: “i suggst [sic] you reach out to Bill Burns and tell him you are there if he needs help. I’ll explain on phone.”

Epstein followed [up the next day](#) in a typically error strewn email. “I think John Kerry , might be busy for awhile. they will turn to Bill Burns who will need more help.”

In April 2014, Burns announced he was resigning after 32 years in the government. He was such an influential figure in diplomacy that the New York Times, NPR and other media covered his decision to step away from government.

The next month, Epstein [emailed financier Peter Thiel](#), claiming that Burns, along with Ehud Barak and Rød-Larsen, “will all be at the house on june 1”. It is unclear what he meant. There is no evidence that Burns was there, and his spokesperson told the Guardian that Burns did not attend that meeting.

In July, Epstein referred to Burns [yet again](#) when he was invited to Russia by an official in the Russian central bank. “At some point I would love bill burns views on whether I should or not,” Epstein wrote to Rød-Larsen.

There is no evidence that Epstein or anyone else actually asked for Burns's view at the time, and Burns's spokesperson said there was no correspondence.

The following month there was an actual meeting.

Epstein's assistant **emailed** the financier on 19 August: "Bill Burns is in a meeting now ... his assistant will have him call you once he is out of the meeting." Burns finally met with Epstein on 21 August at the DC law office of Steptoe, a white-shoe firm, for lunch, as the Wall Street Journal first reported in a story in 2023 about Epstein's calendar.

Epstein, then a convicted sex offender, had gone to the US Treasury that morning, according to his calendar. There is no hint why. Then at noon that day, he met with Burns.

Burns's spokesperson said that the subject matter concerned Burns's efforts for his career post-government. **Ten days later, on 1 September**, Epstein started to text Burns, following up.

"Bill," wrote Epstein, "Peter thiel will be with me 13,14 in ny . I think it would be nice for you to meet if convenient for you . There is an apt for you to use if you choose."

The next afternoon, Burns responded: "Many thanks for your thoughtfulness. Will try to come up either 13 or 14, although I may have to travel overseas. Will confirm as soon as I can. Will also be in NY week of 9/22. Warm regards, Bill,"

Burns's text indicates he tried to make the meeting happen. "Thanks for your patience. Would a mid or late afternoon meeting Sat be possible ?" he wrote. "I would have to get back to DC that evening. My boss will be away, and I expect to spend most of weekend in WH meetings. Unusually busy time here. Many thanks."

A meeting appears to have been scheduled for 13 September, but then canceled. "Very sorry," Burns texted on the 12th, "but I now have to take a short overseas trip this weekend, following up President's ISIL speech. Please give my best to Peter, and look forward to another opportunity to

meet soon. Many thanks again for your thoughtfulness -- I'll be in NY week of Sept 22, and would enjoy seeing you if you have any time. All best."

Later that week, according to a state department [media release](#), on 17 and 18 September, Burns was in New York for meetings with Iranian officials. Epstein [texted](#) him to request his availability in New York and Burns politely responded.

"I'm in NY all week of 9/22 (Mon-Fri). Schedule is pretty hectic, but would very much like to see you. What windows might work best for you ? I'll try to accomodate. All best," Burns wrote.

The two agreed to meet on 24 September. On 26 September, two days after the meeting, Epstein texted Burns again: "Do you have email for friend?

Burns writes: "Sorry to be slow. Which email ? Mine is [redacted]. Enjoyed seeing you earlier this week." That was the last communication in the files from Burns to Epstein. Just after midnight the day after the meeting at the townhouse, Epstein texted billionaire Reid Hoffman: "Also you should meet bill burns."

Burns's spokesperson said that it was soon after this meeting that Burns learned about Epstein's criminal conviction in Florida and cut off ties.

Epstein continued to mention Burns in some emails and texts, and even seemed aware of his travels. In November 2014, Epstein [referred](#) to Burns again in an email to billionaire Tom Pritzker: "Bill Burns was in the vi [Virgin Islands] last week." Burns's spokesperson said Burns didn't know how or why Epstein knew about his trip to the Virgin Islands, and that it had nothing to do with Epstein.

The last time Burns's name appears in the files is 27 March 2018, in the midst of a [multiday text chain](#) between Epstein and former Trump strategist Steve Bannon. Apparently out of the blue, Epstein said: "I suggest you meet Bill Burns." Burns's spokesperson said a meeting with Bannon "did not happen".

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